



junior; I made my debut recently. I faced Samson in the Vijay Hazare Trophy last year, so to take his wicket is a huge achievement. It's an honour. The plan was formed on the ground — Mayank [Agarwal] *bhaiyaa* said I could try a bouncer if I wanted to since Samson was new at the crease," Aaqib explained.

Other notable performers included Anshul Kamboj, the tournament's highest wicket-taker with 16 scalps, Manav Suthar and Shams Mulani. Suthar and Rawat have found a place in the Rest of India squad for the upcoming Irani Cup, which will be played in Lucknow from October 1 to 5.

This edition of the Duleep Trophy also tested India's bench strength, particularly with a five-match series in Australia looming. The Anantapur wickets offered assistance to pacers, who were under scrutiny.

During the last tour of Australia in 2021, India had as many as six fast bowlers in the squad at one point. Akash's nine-wicket haul in the first

round earned him a spot in the squad for the first Bangladesh Test, positioning him as the first backup to the pace trio of Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, and Mohammed Shami. However, the selectors will have even more options after strong showings from Mukesh Kumar (15 wickets), Navdeep Saini (14 wickets), and Arshdeep Singh (13 wickets). The return of Avesh Khan and Prasidh Krishna from injury has further bolstered India's pace options for the big tour.

Some of these pacers might even get an earlier opportunity, with the upcoming three-match Test series against New Zealand.

For the batters, the tournament yielded mixed results. Shreyas Iyer scored 154 runs in six innings but was let down by his attacking instincts on several occasions. Suryakumar Yadav, who returned to red-ball cricket in 2022/23 after nearly three seasons, managed only eight runs in his sole Test innings against Australia last year. Still

Standout performer: India C's Anshul Kamboj was a standout performer in this year's Duleep Trophy, claiming 16 wickets, including a remarkable eight-wicket haul.

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hopeful of a comeback, Suryakumar participated in the final round, scoring 5 and 16.

In contrast, Kishan and Samson struck centuries, making positive strides with the former even being included in the Rest of India squad. A strong showing in the Irani Cup and then the Ranji Trophy could pave the way for Kishan's return to the top tier of Indian cricket.

Meanwhile, solid performances from Sudharsan and Padikkal should help alleviate concerns about India's batting transition, expected to begin after the 2025 World Test Championship final, when Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma could consider hanging up their boots from the longer format.